

The one-page decision memo

Blank. Six blocks, in this order, because the order is most of the work. The worked version on the scheduling assistant is the separate three-page pack.

One page. If it runs to two, the second page is an appendix, and the appendix is for you, not for them. Fill this in, then rewrite it in your own document — the point is the blocks and their order, not this paper.

BLOCK 1 · THE DECISION

What are you asking, of whom, by when, and what do you need beyond a yes? First two lines, or it is a status update.

BLOCK 2 · WHAT IT DOES

The one flow, in a sentence somebody who has never used it would follow. Not the architecture.

BLOCK 3 · IS IT GOOD

The set, the rubric (dated), the number you got by running it, the bar you wrote first, and the real-traffic number — above the flattering one. Ranked failure counts.

BLOCK 4 · WHAT IT COSTS

Per request (with the token count), at forecast volume, what makes it ten times bigger, the lever, and the latency a user actually waits for.

BLOCK 5 · WHEN IT IS WRONG

The worst plausible wrong action, severity and reversibility, the gate, what it may not touch, and what you tested.

BLOCK 6 · WHAT I STILL DO NOT KNOW

Two or three, each with what would settle it and how long. Plus: what would make you kill it.

THE JUDGEMENT PARAGRAPH · WHAT THE AI GOT WRONG, AND WHAT YOU DID

Appendix, not on this page: the spec, the rubric and its date, the golden set, the traces you read, the cost working, the test log.

The five minutes, and the drill

What you say, in what order, and the ten questions to run against your own page before anybody else does.

THE FIVE MINUTES · WRITE THE FIRST SENTENCE OF EACH BEAT, THEN SAY IT OUT LOUD, TIMED

0:00 → 1:00 · THE DECISION

No screen. The ask, in one sentence. If you open the prototype here, the room starts designing and you leave with feedback.

1:00 → 2:30 · THE EVIDENCE

The worse number first. Then the better one. Then the ranked counts, and what the top two would take to fix.

2:30 → 3:30 · COST

Per request, at volume, the ten-times risk, the lever. One sentence each.

3:30 → 4:30 · RISK

Worst wrong action, the gate, withheld capabilities, what you tested.

4:30 → 5:00 · THE ASK

Repeat the decision, the date, the owner. Ask for them to be written down.

THE DRILL · TICK THE ONES YOU CAN ANSWER FROM A DOCUMENT YOU ALREADY HAVE

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| ☐ What does it cost? → your cost model | ☐ Who decided what good means? → you did, in writing, dated |
| ☐ What if it takes off? → the same model, next row | ☐ What happens when it is wrong? → the gate |
| ☐ Why not a cheaper model? → because you measured | ☐ Could it do something we would have to apologise for? → the tools list |
| ☐ Why not the better one? → the bend, Lesson 6.2 | ☐ Why now, rather than next quarter? → the counts and the fix |
| ☐ How do you know it is any good? → your rubric and the run | ☐ What would you need to go further? → the pilot's number, and the unknowns |

THE TWO YOU CANNOT ANSWER · NAME THEM BEFORE THEY ARE ASKED

I do not know _____. What would tell us: _____, and it takes _____. Either way I would _____.

HOW THE MEETING ENDS · THREE LINES, WRITTEN DOWN, BEFORE ANYBODY STANDS UP

The decision: _____ The date: _____ Who owns it: _____

Send the page that afternoon with those three lines at the top, to everyone who was there and the two people who were not. A meeting that ends on nodding is a meeting you will hold again in a fortnight.

IF THEY RE-SCOPE YOU LIVE

Do not argue, do not agree on the spot. Say what it changes — different users, a different set, a different bar, and how long to find out — then ask: **instead, or after?**

The two questions you cannot answer are worth more than the eight you can, if you name them first.